

Popular Kenyan Last Names, Their Meanings and Digital Presence



TL;DR: Popular Kenyan Last Names

- Kenyan surnames carry deep meaning, reflecting birth order, time of birth, seasons, lineage, and ethnic identity.
- Across communities like the Kikuyu, Luo, Kalenjin, Kamba, and Luhya, surnames preserve family history thrc generations.
- Today, your surname is also **digital real estate**.
- Domain names operate on a first-come, first-served basis, if someone registers *yoursurname.co.ke*, reclaiming it can be difficult or expensive.
- Influential figures like **Wangari Maathai** and **Ngũgĩ wa Thiong’o** highlighted the cultural power of names, today that power extends online.
- Securing your surname as a domain protects your family’s digital identity, future business opportunities, a professional credibility.
- You do not need to build a website immediately, you simply need to secure the name before someone els does.

A Kenyan surname carries ethnic group identity, history, geography, and family stories. They often reflect birth order among siblings, time of birth, seasons, events, physical traits, or lineage. It is like a family line that passes from father to child, generation after generation.

But here is what most families are overlooking: your last name is also digital real estate.

Every day, more personal names are being registered as domains. Once someone secures *yoursurname.co.ke* you cannot claim it back easily, if ever.

Before you continue reading, secure your last name for future use. If it is still available, secure it first.

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Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

- [Luo Surnames](#)
- [Kamba Surnames](#)
- [Kalenjin Surnames](#)
- [Luhya Surnames](#)
- [How Kenyan Naming Traditions Work](#)
- [Examples of Powerful Kenyan Names](#)
- [Why Risk Losing Your Name Online?](#)

Kenyan Last Names and Their Meanings

In Kenya, surnames are inherited from the father. The father’s name becomes the child’s last name and the grandfather’s name echoes in the grandchildren. This is true across almost all ethnic communities — Kikuyu, Luo, Kamba, Kalenjin, Luhya, and beyond.

Here are some of the most popular Kenyan surnames born from this principle:

Kikuyu Surnames

The Kikuyu are Kenya’s largest ethnic community and their surnames are among the most common in the country. Many are rooted in birth order, family structure, and ancestral lineage.

Mwangi – Often interpreted as ‘rapid expansion’ — someone strong and fast-growing. One of Kenya’s most common surnames.

Kamau – A boy born after a girl in Kikuyu naming tradition. Now widely used as a family surname.

Kariuki – Linked to agricultural growth; ‘one who springs up.’ Common across the Mt. Kenya region.

Njoroge – Associated with cattle herding or pastoral traditions.

Kinyua – Linked to farming and cultivation roots.

Njenga – Tied to resilience and strength within the family.

Karanja – Often associated with leadership or authority within ethnic group structures.

Ndungu – Refers to someone born in dry or drought conditions.

Gichuru – Associated with ethnic group lineage among the Kikuyu.

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Luo Surnames

The Luo of Western Kenya have a distinctive naming system built around time of birth. These names are deep tied to lineage and the father’s name passes forward as a surname through generations.

Odhiambo – A boy born in the evening.

Otieno – A boy born at night. One of the most recognizable Luo surnames.

Ochieng – A boy born during daylight hours.

Omondi – A boy born early in the morning.

Onyango – A boy born in the early morning hours. A very common Luo surname.

Owino – A Luo surname tied to lineage and paternal ancestry.

Achieng – A girl born during daylight; also carried as a family surname.

Anyango – A girl born in the morning.

Atieno – A girl born at night.

Kamba Surnames

The Kamba of Eastern Kenya have strong naming traditions tied to family events, birth circumstances, and seasonal cycles. Their surnames reflect a deep connection to land and lineage.

Mutua – Often given to a child born after the loss of another child. A name that carries both grief and renewal.

Musyoka – Connected to agricultural seasons or ethnic group lineage.

Kioko – Refers to someone born in the morning.

Kilonzo – A Kamba surname linked to family lineage.

Muli – Often refers to ‘second born’ in Kamba tradition.

Mulwa – Associated with traditional Kamba naming customs.

Nzioka – Refers to someone born during specific seasonal periods.

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- Kiptoo** – A boy born at night in Kalenjin tradition.
- Kibet** – A boy born during the day.
- Kiprono** – A boy born during migration or movement.
- Kiprotich** – A boy born during sunny daylight hours.
- Ruto** – Associated with birth along a journey or road. Now one of Kenya’s most recognized surnames.
- Koech** – Linked to agricultural or environmental birth conditions.
- Langat** – A Kalenjin name associated with nature and the environment.
- Rotich** – Linked to cattle-keeping traditions.
- Biwott** – A Kalenjin surname connected to ethnic group identity.
- Sang** – A short Kalenjin surname tied to lineage.
- Too** – A shortened Kalenjin surname linked to birth timing.
- Chebet** – A girl born during the day; also used as a family surname.
- Cherono** – A girl born during times of migration or travel.

Luhya Surnames

The Luhya of Western Kenya are a diverse cluster of sub-communities. Their surnames carry strong ties to heritage, ancestry, and seasonal farming traditions.

- Barasa** – A name tied to Luhya ethnic group lineage.
- Simiyu** – Associated with ethnic group identity across Luhya communities.
- Were** – Tied to heritage and ancestry; common across Western Kenya.
- Masinde** – Popular in Western Kenya, connected to ethnic group names.
- Wekesa** – A boy born during harvest season — one of the most recognizable Luhya surnames.
- Naliaka** – A Luhya female name referring to birth during the weeding season.
- Nabwire** – Often refers to a girl born at night.

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Many communities name children based on time of birth.

Among the Luo:

- Otieno refers to a boy born at night
- Odhiambo refers to a boy born in the evening
- Ochieng refers to a boy born during the day
- Achieng refers to a girl born during daylight

Among the Kalenjin:

- Kip often refers to a boy
- Chep or Jep often refers to a girl
- Kipchoge relates to being born near granaries
- Chebet often refers to a girl born during the day

Other surnames reflect **birth order**.

In Kikuyu naming traditions:

- Kamau is often a boy born after a girl
- Wanjiru can reflect a specific order in the family structure

Some **names are linked to seasons and agriculture**, which makes sense when land and farming shaped generations.

Examples:

- Wekesa refers to someone born during harvest
- Muthoni relates to harvest season
- Naliaka refers to birth during weeding season

Then there are surnames tied to **circumstances or events**.

- Mutua is often given to a child born after the loss of another
- Ndungu can refer to drought conditions
- Ruto can relate to birth along a journey

Finally, many surnames are deeply tied to ethnic group identity and lineage. In communities like the Luhya and Kikuyu, surnames signal extended family connections and ancestral roots.

This structure matters. When you see that your surname carries information about time, season, struggle, or lineage, it stops being “just a name.” It becomes a heritage that deserves protection and forward thinking.

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Excellent, I found exactly what I needed!

If someone else controls your surname online, they control what appears when your name is searched. Visibility under your own name should not be left to chance.

Why Risk Losing Your Name Online?

Here is the reality: domain registries operate on a first-come, first-served basis.

There is no system that protects surnames by tribe, lineage, or cultural ownership. If someone registers `mwangi.co.ke` before you, it legally belongs to them even if your family has carried that name for generations.

Because surnames pass through the father’s line, one domain registration protects an entire family tree, not just one person.

And this is already happening.

Common Kenyan surnames are being registered by:

- Businesses building household names
- Individuals building personal brands
- Diaspora Kenyans securing .com versions
- Domain investors who see value in common surnames

The more common the surname, the higher the risk.

Think about names like Mwangi, Otieno, Kipchoge, Mutua, Wekesa. These are not rare, which makes them attractive as domains.

Now add two more factors:

1. Kenya’s digital growth is accelerating.
2. More professionals are building websites instead of relying only on social media.

With all that in mind, you do not need to build a website immediately. You only need to secure the name.

For the cost of a domain registration, you protect:

1. Your family’s digital identity
2. Future business opportunities
3. Professional credibility
4. Email addresses under your own name

How helpful was this article?



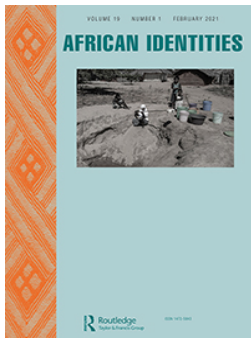
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What's in a name? Reinventing Luo naming system in Kenya's ethnopolitical landscape

Belindah Okello

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ARTICLE



What's in a name? Reinventing Luo naming system in Kenya's ethnopolitical landscape

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines an emergent naming subculture gaining popularity among ethnic Luo in the urban areas of Mombasa and Nairobi. The paper posits that the naming pattern is embedded in the development of Kenya's ethnopolitical landscape which has placed ethnic Luo at an economically, socially and politically disadvantaged position. Though popular in linguistic and anthropological circles, the field of anthroponymy has received little attention from Africanist historians. This dearth is especially curious since naming systems still bear significant meaning to large segments of the continent's populations. Names are pointers to identities; identities that have been used world over to create binaries of 'us' and 'them'. Every so often, identities have been determinants of individuals' primary existence. Because of its centrality in existentiality, societies constantly consolidate, manipulate and restructure identities in order to fit in, dominate or survive. This evaluation of the development and changes of Luo naming system is therefore an attempt at understanding identities reimagined to adapt to a society's history, systems and structures.

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Naming systems; identity; ethnicity; Luo; governance; Kenya

1 Introduction

The theme of ethnicity and how it has manifested through Kenya's history since the colonial period features prominently in Yvonne Adhiambo's novel *Dust* (Adhiambo, 2014). This paper borrows from Adhiambo's theme on naming and ethnicity to argue that the collective memory and experiences of ethnic Luo in Kenya has contributed to the emergence and the continuous adoption of a new naming system. A main character in *Dust*; Keya, was able to move ranks and become powerful in the Kenya police partly due to his name not overtly revealing his ethnic identity. The name 'Keya', derived from localizing KAR (Kings African Rifles battalion of World War II), helped him navigate the ethnopolitical landscape in Kenya's early post-independence civil service. His counterpart Nyipir Oganda had a different experience. In analyzing the adoption of this new naming system, the paper will endeavor to answer the question of to what extent Kenya's history with ethnicity and how it has been experienced by the Luo has contributed to the emergence of this practice.

Secondly, the paper will look into why the new naming system is becoming more prevalent amongst middle-class Luo, and in the urban areas.

Individuals use ethnic identities to categorize themselves and others for purposes of interaction (Barth, 1998, p. 11). The differences applied to categorize are usually not objective but only regarded as significant by the actors. These identities enable humans to feel they are part of an organizational structure and sets them apart from those categorized as others. Appiah (2018) describes identities as imagined commonalities that create unity within an in-group and ostracize those they consider to be of a differing out-group. He argues that identities are fluid and are built upon by making alterations and additions to a primary idea. Giving an example of Western culture which he posits began as an attempt to counter the influence of a burgeoning Islamic culture (but would later morph into a complete system of governance, architecture, moralities, etc.) identities he argues, become reinforced at the locus of conflict rather than being the primary cause of it.

The paper begins by outlining some literature on naming and identity, underlining the nexus between the two themes, and hence outlines how anthroponyms can be used as tools for deciphering the history of people. This will be followed by discussing the theoretical framework by which this analysis will be understood. Then, I will delve into the evolution of Luo naming system beginning with naming practices in the precolonial era and weave through the changes occasioned by various factors in history until finally coming to a conclusion in the present era of the new modifications. Next, the paper will tackle the methodology used to collect information on the new naming practices and outline the results of the study from the interviewees' perspective. Finally, the paper will scrutinize the development of Kenya's ethno-political landscape juxtaposing it against the experience of the Luo; and in this explain how these developments triggered the adoption of a new naming system.

2 Literature Review

A name is one of the most explicit pointers of identity. Likaka (2009), posits that names constitute the essence of the individual, embodying their experiences, memories, thoughts and actions. He asserts that names are sites of observation and perception, and have been used as avenues for encoding myths, metaphors, and for reflection. Suzman (1994, p. 253) argues that names are not arbitrary labels but have sociocultural meanings and possess referential functions. Herbert (1999) agrees to this assertion in his assessment of African political names, arguing that personal names offer social commentary and that names in Africa are used as avenues for keeping the history of people.

One of the most prolific works on the philosophy guiding African naming is Mbiti's *African Religions and Philosophy* (Mbiti, 1969). This work points out the importance given to the processes of naming in various African societies and includes examples of ceremonies and general guidelines applied by different communities. Mbiti maintains that it is through these processes that a child is connected to not only a family but also to an entire ethnic group. The converging of the living, the dead and a newborn in naming processes relays the significance a name plays in the formation of communal identity. Agyekum's (2006) examination of the sociocultural meanings attributed to Akan names details the complexities of gender, social standing, place, among other factors involved in arriving at

particular personal names. This work shows that in Africa, a name is arrived at after careful considerations. Work on naming practices among the Luo includes examination of their clan naming system (Malo, 1953; Mboya, 1938; Ogot, 1967; Southall, 1952); the works revealing a connection between Luo migration and settlement pattern in their clan naming practices. Southall demonstrates the links between clan naming with a progenitor thus situating naming within social identity. Mboya's elaboration of the significance of 'proper' Luo socialization through practices such as naming, and his arguments that it is through such that the cooperate association of the Luo will survive in the face of colonialism and the foreign cultures of urban areas reveals the importance placed on identity in culturally ambiguous locales.

Nyambi et al. (2016) posit that names are important yet often underestimated socio-political-cultural sites on which some of the most significant events and processes of the post colony can be read. Naming patterns change over time and are often influenced by people's history. Likaka's (2009) work on the naming of Europeans in the Congo, and how it was influenced by their experience of colonialism reveals that names can be used as avenues of expression of experiences hence as subtle responses to lived experiences. Suzman (1994) analysis of the changes in naming systems among the Zulu from traditional naming patterns and their transitioning through processes of western acculturation situates naming within the history of people. Epstein's (1958) study of the urban community in a mining town in the Copperbelt region of Zambia recognizes that social relationships develop within a setting that is continuously changing, and affected by increasing diversification of customs. The findings of these authors correspond to Luo naming practices which have changed and evolved, the changes being subject to a myriad of factors including; pre-colonial migrations, Christianity, colonial and post-colonial labor migrations, Western education, among other factors. Colonial labor migrations and later rural-urban migrations especially contributed to the development of what has been termed as 'distinct Luo names'; the distinct character being almost all male names beginning with the prefix 'O' and female names with the prefix 'A'. Currently, however, there is a shift in Luo naming system among the young urban middle-class population. As Dixon (2000) argues, 'who we are' is often intimately related to questions of 'where we are'. This paper will interrogate the connection between this change in naming pattern in the urban areas, and Kenya's history with negative ethnicity.

3 Theoretical Framework

The theory of historical trauma will be applied in analyzing the changes of naming patterns among middle-class ethnic Luo living in the urban areas of Nairobi and Mombasa. Historical trauma is a term that has been used to describe the long-term impact of colonization, cultural suppression, and historical oppression of individuals. The construct has been mostly applied in the study of indigenous peoples in the Western world, including Native Americans in the United States and Aboriginal peoples like the Inuit and Metis of Canada (Crawford, 2014; Kirmayer et al., 2014; Walters et al., 2011). The term is also mainly used in psychology and in the medical field to analyze the physiological and psychological effects traumatic experiences of oppression have on a group. Historical trauma spans multiple generations, such that contemporary members of an affected group may experience trauma-related symptoms without having been

present for the past traumatizing events (Crawford, 2014). Effects of historical trauma are usually negative.

Although historical trauma has been used to analyze the medical effects of oppression, the concept can also be applied in analyzing the positive coping mechanisms that can/ have been applied by groups of oppressed individuals. Kirmayer et al. (2014) argue that the continued oppression of people is in actuality a result of existing structures of oppression rather than the trauma in itself. Hence, contends that the theory of historical trauma should be more appropriately used to analyze the adaptations individuals/groups develop in order to minimize the effects of oppression. This paper shall apply historical trauma in this context. The paper will argue that a large section of especially middle-class Luo in Mombasa and Nairobi are cognizant of the possibility of their ethnicity becoming a hindrance in their quest for upward social mobility and even their personal safety. This affirmation stems from memories of oppression in successive post-independence Kenyan governments. Coupled with uncertainties over the new political dispensation of devolution and decentralization, their experiences of historical trauma are pushing them towards adopting names giving anonymity to their children.

4 Evolution of Luo naming System

Before embarking on a narrative evaluation of the changes and evolution of Luo naming system, I shall illustrate the changes in the following three Tables.

Table 1. Examples of cultural Luo names.

Name	Origins of the name
Gor	Ancient Luo warrior
Wadiya	Found mainly in the Suba regions. Name believed to have Bantu origins
Gombe	One of the progenies of the Ugenya clans
Boro	One of the progenies of the Alego clans

N.B. Traditional naming was largely gender neutral, though it was more common for women to possess 'male names' than the other way.

Table 2. Examples of 'common' Luo names.

Circumstance surrounding birth	Luo translation	Male	Female
Rain	'Koth	Okoth	Akoth
Mist	'Luoch	Oluoch	Aluoch
Sun	'Chieng	Ochieng	Achieng
Night	'Tieno	Otieno	Atieno

N.B. The supposed commonality shall be explained in the narration

Table 3. Examples of new names gaining ground.

Positive trait considered	Luo translation	Male	Female
Strength	Teko	Teko	Teko
Blessings	Gweth/Mich	Gweth/Mich	Gweth/Mich
Happiness	Mor	Mor	Mor
Shining star	Sulwe	Sulwe	Sulwe

Luo cultural naming system has been captured in various academic and fictional literatures (Malo, 1953; Mbiti, 1969; Mboya, 1938; Ogola, 1994; Ogot, 1967; Southall, 1952). Children were named by their kin and names given were in most cases those of the living dead or ancestral figures who wanted the continuation of their legacy in the living. A preferred name for a child would come to a kin (*wat*) in form of a dream; the dead relation asking the *wat* to relay their desire to have a child named after them (Ogola, 1994). If no dead relation willed to be renamed, parents had a free hand in giving out a name (Ohanga, Oral interview 20 June 2018). In such a circumstance, parents would give a child a personal name which usually was an indication of the circumstances surrounding their birth. A prefix 'O' or 'A' would in most cases be affixed to a circumstance to arrive at a name. If, for example, a child was born on a rainy day, their name would mean rain 'koth'; thus 'Akoth', or 'Okoth' for a girl and boy, respectively. The concept of family name did not exist and individuals' names included a personal name, together with a 'surname' which was the personal name of one's legal father. 'Surnames' were therefore different for members within a patriarchal group.

Arguably, the abovementioned naming system is an oversimplified representation of an elaborate process. Naming systems were in actuality complicated processes often punctuated with the application of extra-ordinary naming patterns and ritual performances to fulfil special circumstances. There would be, for example, a different naming system applicable if there was a general belief that evil may befall an infant. The above narration however constitutes the basic of naming systems among the Luo in instances where no exceptional circumstances were in play. In addition, the emergent naming pattern in the analysis is contextualized within the transitions occasioned by colonial experiences which will be discussed further herein; hence, this narration will suffice.

A dramatic shift in Luo naming system came about in the colonial period through two major avenues. Firstly, the introduction of a formal education system, initially given by Christian missionaries who required conversion (Okello & Nyakwaka, 2016) led to the adoption of western names baptized as 'Christian names'. Hereafter bearing a European name together with an ethnic name became the norm first among the educated, but later the practice was evenly adopted. Secondly, colonization came with rapid urbanization and an advent of labor migration with a large section of ethnic Luo becoming labor migrants in upcoming urban areas, colonial farms, and industrial districts. Migrant laborers were initially unaccompanied young men (Janmohamed, 1979; Stichter, 1985). Later, however, male laborers were allowed to tag their wives and families along to live with them (Cooper, 1987). This meant that a young nuclear family was broken from the direct influence of extended family relations. As a consequence, earlier restrictions on naming patterns became weakened and naming shifted from being a communal activity to a personal one. Migrant parents thence began relying on circumstances surrounding their children's birth to name them. The time of day and surrounding weather conditions became the most common of circumstance; thus, the Luo born in the urban areas began acquiring characteristic names (See Table 2). To other ethnic groups especially, all Luo names began with prefixes 'O' and 'A'. Other names were however still given by extended relatives and even friends whenever the family in the urban area visited. Individuals sometimes possessed as many as eight names which were fluid, and easily changed to satisfy varied interests.¹

In the later colonial and much of the post-colonial years, government bureaucratization in form of birth certificates and identity cards meant that individuals were stuck with names originally ascribed. Henceforth, changing one's ethnic name to fit into particular circumstances became impossible. Kenya's social and political space was at the same time, increasingly becoming ethnically divided. The ethnic structuring of society gradually determined personal fortunes and in time one's name directly influenced their chances of upward mobility and even, personal safety. These insecurities were especially felt by the Luo in urban areas. Soon, Luo parents came to the realization that if their children names become anonymous to surrounding ethnic groups, they were much more likely to survive Kenya's ethnicized space. Hence, a subculture constituting of a new naming system is slowly being adopted with the purposes of keeping Luo ethnic identity intact but anonymous. The parents hope that this action will safeguard their children's personal safety and at the same time ensures a wider space for upward social mobility.

4.1 Methodology and Results of the study

This paper is part of a larger inquiry on the challenges of integration among urban ethnic Luo of Kenya. The overall inquiry interviewed respondents from ages 15, but data for this paper constituted only a subset of the whole sample group; that is families whose children possess covert² Luo names. These respondents numbered 20. An evaluation of the naming system among this sample group revealed a departure from the traditional ethnic Luo practice of the circumstances of one's birth determining one's name. In addition, there is a conscious choice to move away from the use of the prefix 'O' and 'A' (See Table 3). Obviously, not all Luo names begin with the prefixes 'O' and 'A'. In homes where the father's surname did not begin with these prefixes, the concept of family name was more likely adopted. In multi-ethnic homes, the non-Luo parent would usually push for giving of anonymous Luo names compared to obvious ones. The patriarchal nature of most households aided in reaching the compromises towards the new naming system with most male Luo partners willing to adopt covert Luo names rather than have children identified with names from their maternal ethnic group. The prevalence of this new naming pattern is highest among middle-class families (compared to low-income families); and increases with a decrease in the age of parents. The prevalence can be explained by understanding the characterization of the middle class in Nairobi and Mombasa. As analyzed by Boanada-Fuchs and Gez et al. (2016), Kroeker (2017), and Institute of Economic Affairs (2016), the middle class in Kenya's urban spaces have more interactions (work, marriages, school) with other ethnic groups than their counterparts in the rural areas, or even among the urban poor. They also have less linkages with their ancestral homes³ with some being third and fourth generations of colonial immigrant kin. In addition, the middle class have less communal socio-support mechanisms comparable to those experienced by ethnic counterparts in the rural areas and among the urban poor. The middle class, therefore, have limited support mechanisms to fall back on in case they fall on hard times. Thus, an adaptation to their identity to mitigate against these hard times seems appropriate.

Where one ethnic group has control of the means of production utilized by another group, a relationship of inequality and stratification is likely to occur (Barth, 1998). He adds that in most cases, a section in the minority group reacts to their situation and become

agents of change. These agents of change are the persons with greater contacts and more dependence on goods and organization of the society controlled by the majority. In their quest to participate in wider social systems they would usually choose the following strategies. Firstly, they may attempt to pass and become in cooperated in the pre-established majority society and cultural group. Secondly, they may accept their minority status but seek to reduce and accommodate their minority disabilities while participating in the systems controlled by the majority. A third option would be to choose to emphasize their ethnic identity, using it to develop new positions and patterns of organization. This paper discusses the adoption of the second option by middle-class Luo (the agents of change), revealing that the new naming system is a response to minimize the effects of ethnicity in an urban setting.

4.2 The development of Kenya's ethnopolitical space

Conflict amongst ethnic groups was a common feature in pre-colonial societies. Ethnic groups regularly battled each other over space and resources; thus, displacement and assimilation of sections of populations was not uncommon. Distinct ethnic identities were not particularly formed and ethnic groups drew their common identities majorly from their clan system rather than from aspects such as language or shared history (Ambler, 1988). The Abamarachi sections of the Abaluhya, for example, would constantly raid the Abatachoni eventually forcing the latter to construct defensive forts (Ogutu, 1991). Another example would be the Luo of Alego who considered the Luo of Gem, Sakwa, Kisuma and other subgroups as a different tribe (sic) common language notwithstanding (Nundu, 1982; Ogot, 1967; Southall, 1952).

Colonialism radically restructured the face of ethnic conflict; majorly through the creation, encouragement and institutionalization of clear ethnic identities among African populations (Ambler, 1988; Berman & Wolff, 1978). Ambler opines that defining ethnicity, with specific ethnic groups possessing clear and definite abilities was a scheme to enable easier subjugation of local populations. Berman (1990) contends adding that ethnicizing and the ensuing preferential treatment for particular groups resulted in not only suspicion amongst ethnic groups but also growing resentment towards each other. Imagined ethnic identities would later become crucial instruments of state organization and control of populations.

Since the colonial period, the ability to control all organs of the state has been a key element in the development of the bourgeoisie class. The colonial administration enabled this control by way of creation of a powerful civil service, which controlled local politics and economy and ultimately led to state capture⁴ with its attendant economic and social controls of the population (Bienen, 1974; Himbara, 1994). This continued in the post colony and the battle for control of the civil service (which was essentially the battle to become part of the bourgeoisie) shaped the development of Kenya's ethnopolitical space (Burbidge, 2016; Odinga, 1995; Shilaho, 2018). In the immediate post-colonial period, the emergent African bourgeoisie class determined to protect their position, ensured that all powerful posts in the civil service, police and armed forces were filled by their fellow tribespeople. Thus, the ethnic group of whoever was in power became the dominant group in the civil service and ensured tribal hegemony. Ethnicity influenced government formation and operation, influenced opposition to government, and was used as

a defining factor to include/exclude certain groups in/from political participation. The control of the organizational structure of the state was fused to ethnicities and this determined economic fortunes. It became highly unlikely for an individual to acquire anything without it having been stamped by organs of the civil service. A 1972 ILO report aptly described the situation as:

Kenya inherited a very lopsided economy already organised for the effective maintenance of very different ways of life for a tiny minority on the one hand, and a very large majority on the other. Kenyanisation has radically changed the racial composition of the group of people at the centre of power and many of its policies, but has had only a limited effect on the mechanisms which maintain its dominance. The power of the centre over the periphery may well be greater today than it was before (ILO, 1972, pp. 83–102)

Luo exclusion from government (civil service) began with the Odinga/Kenyatta ideological battle shortly after independence. Odinga preferred socialism arguing that it was best suited in helping African nations achieve development after the experiences of colonialism (Cullen, 2018; Oruka, 1992). He added that Africans had inherent socialism structures within their communities thus the African state would be best suited to follow a familiar path towards development. President Kenyatta preferred capitalism arguing that to spur development, the country needed to quickly integrate into the world economy through the capitalist system of free market (Cullen, 2018). This ideological war led to the breakup of the independence party Kenya African National Union (KANU) and the formation of the socialist Kenya Peoples Union (KPU) by Odinga. The Luo effectively became Odinga's associates by way of ethnic linkages. As a result, they became politically side-lined, labelled anti-government and were linked with opposition politics, a tag which made the community a prime target for political and economic exclusion (Omollo, Oral interview 13 December 2017; Bienen, 1974; Himbara, 1994; Omulo & Williams, 2018; Shilaho, 2018). This was best exhibited in their exclusion from the civil service.

Other than its mechanisms of controlling state organs, the civil service was the most attractive agency of employment. At independence, Kenya's labor laws were adapted from the colonial laws whose practices were quite discriminatory to the African worker. Although steps had been made to improve the position of laborers through trade unionism and legislations, labor laws were still relatively weak. In addition, a large section of the population was uneducated hence unable to fully understand and internalize matters labor rights. Being part of the civil service was more or less the only known mechanism of labor protection. Because of the relatively small size of the civil service (owing to low education standards) civil servants also received perks including the possibility of time off to pursue higher education and trainings which would later translate to promotions. Entry into the civil service, therefore, became a crucial step towards upward economic and social mobility.

The economic downturn of the 1970s greatly increased the value of employment in the civil service. In a country that was yet to recover from the effects of colonialism, inflation, low wages, and a raised cost of living led to a staggering deterioration of the economy. In an effort to appease the civil service which was the main tool for state control, the Kenya Public Structure and Remuneration Committee formed in 1971 made recommendations to allow civil servants engage in private businesses to supplement incomes. This move

goaded corruption and negative ethnicity as civil servants began using their position to grow and expand private enterprises. Ethnic brokerage became pivotal in the entry to the civil service with the broker becoming an institutionalized feature in the work environment (ILO, 1972; Omulo & Williams, 2018). At the grassroots level, life became harder as everyone struggled to position themselves in the new economic dispensation. Citizens became easily susceptible and readily receptive to the political rhetoric of 'us versus them'. Ethnicity thus became a weapon in the struggle for access to available resources (Omulo & Williams, 2018).

The beginning of multi-party politics in the 1990s aggravated the ethnicized landscape in Kenya. At the time for clamor for multi-partyism, president Daniel Moi warned that multi-party politics would lead to the division of the country into ethnic conclaves. When it surely seemed that multiparty was on its way back, calls for federalism (*majimboism*) meant to protect ethnic spheres of influence became louder. Politicians from the Moi's Rift Valley province backyard became prime pushers of federalism, calling for the area to be for the exclusive political nature of the Kalenjin ethnic groups. They openly called for the restoration of the province to its pristine Kalenjin land and expulsion of the Kikuyu, Luo and Luhya (Human rights Watch/Africa Watch, 1993; Weekly Review Magazine, 1992). Moi's 'prophecy' on multi-party politics becoming divisive came to pass at the repeal of section 2A of the constitution which ended one-party rule and allowing multiparty politics. The move triggered the beginning of politically instigated ethnic clashes, and this time again; the Luo became targets for violence.

4.3 Immediate triggers of name change

The urban Luo resolve to change their naming system are directly related to lived experiences, combined with memories of exclusion in the past. Urban Luo live amongst other ethnic groups. The current generation has lived through the violence connected to the introduction of multi-party politics, the infamous 2007 post-election flare-up, and they continue witnessing ethnic bigotry exhibited in the politics of the day. In addition, exclusion from access to resources to enable upward mobility by successive post-independence regimes constitutes their collective ethnic memory.

Due to the fact that the opposition party FORD was headed by an ethnic Luo Oginga Odinga, the initial ethnic violence connected to multi-party politics was meted on the Luo.⁵ However, as multipartyism took shape and multiple political parties began registering ethnic bases, the pattern of violence changed and the Kikuyu began bearing the brunt of election-related violence. In the 2007 post-election flare-up, victims in pro-government areas narrated how they were confronted and forced to produce national identity cards; and if one's bore a Luo name they were attacked (Human Rights Watch Report, 2008; Ogada, Oral Interview 27 January 2018). Ogada said that this incidence led to the decision of naming his children with covert Luo names.

The post-2007 political rhetoric has also been largely anti-Luo. This has been goaded by the growth of the media and ICT that has enabled fast and widespread information sharing, hence making it quite easy to spew ethnic hatred and advance ethnic nationalism to a huge audience. Social media platforms like Facebook and Twitter are popular platforms where anti-Luo sentiments are continuously broadcast. Vernacular radio stations have also been accused of encouraging ethnic bigotry by propagating disinformation and

messages of intolerance that have manipulated the public to resort to violence. The use of obscure and metaphorical language, coupled with wrong contextualization of discussions, make radio stations powerful incitement agents (Media Council of Kenya, 2015). In 2014, for example, when there occurred a terrorist attack in Mpeketoni Lamu district, it was widely circulated (metaphorically of course) in vernacular stations that the opposition leader Raila Odinga was responsible for the attack. This led to violent 'revenge' attacks on Luo not only in Mpeketoni, but in areas as far away as Nairobi's informal settlements of Mathare and Kibera. On several occasions, leaflets have appeared in the urban areas of Nakuru, Eldoret, and Nairobi asking the Luo to leave for their rural homes or face violence (Gitonga, in Standard newspaper, 2014; Capital FM Kenya). In the run-up to the election of 2017 and the immediate period of the disputed election results, random attacks were also meted on the Luo with sexual violence meted on both men and women, forceful circumcision being the main abuse meted on men⁶ (Omulo & Williams, 2018; Kenya National Commission of Human Rights 2017, 2018). Thus, the Luo are increasingly become aware of the need for a covert Luo identity.

The new naming system includes a process of parents identifying a positive trait they wish for their child; translating the word into its ethnic Luo form, hence giving a child a name with a Luo meaning. Such positive features could be strength (Teko), Hope (Hawi), Blessings (Gweth, Mich) Happiness (Mor) among others. Hence, names such as 'Gweth, and Hawi' are gaining popularity while the usual 'Okoth' and 'Aluoch' are losing ground. Parents are hopeful that the ethnically obscure name will enable their children navigate Kenya's ethnically divided society while at the same time; the parents get to pass an aspect of their culture onto their offspring.

5. Conclusion

Identities and feelings of belonging are crucial socio-psycho elements required in the overall development of individuals. Identities have however been also used as tools of oppression hence forcing individuals to apply mechanisms to survive repressive spaces. Grounded on the premise that the new naming system adopted by the Luo is a result of their collective memory and trauma, the paper argues that ethnic Luo, especially in urban areas, are trying to navigate Kenya's ethnicized landscape to enable participation in a system organized to their disadvantage. A new naming system ensures their children get to be Luo among the Luo, while at the same time cushions them from the effects of negative ethnicity while they live amongst other ethnic groups.

Many African governments encounter challenges in managing issues of ethnic diversity. In Kenya, the theme of ethnicity has been a recurring feature in local and international debates, becoming amplified especially during electoral periods. The prominence of this theme points to the need for serious attention and concerted efforts in seeking solutions in its management. Previously suggested solutions such as negotiated democracy in the form of devolution and decentralization have only compounded the problem which manifests in contests between communities during election periods. The high stakes involved in local politics since the introduction of devolution has only increased the risk of communal conflict in local political arenas; and has led to balkanization and the creation of dichotomies of locals and immigrants. Power-sharing options such as the arrangements after the 2007 violence, where power was shared between the president and prime minister managed to only lull disquiet at the top while feelings of discontent

continued simmering at grassroots level. Given that the contests over identities are usually related to resource redistribution, the Kenyan government would probably better manage ethnic animosities by not only leveling the playing field on matters access to resources but also improving the general standards of living for its citizenry.

The processes of government bureaucratization have been a major way in which ethnic identities have been highlighted and amplified. The Kenyan system of identification, for example, is adopted from the colonial registration system whose main agenda was to control the movement of labor. The acquisition of an identity card in Kenya today is a tedious process that has to be approved by authorities not only from one's current residency but also from one's parents. These details which are highlighted in one's identity card only end up unnecessarily amplifying identities and putting the citizenry at precarious positions in case of ethnic conflict. The continuance of registration of ethnic numbers whose main purpose is arguably for negotiating political positionality has also been damaging to efforts towards national cohesion. The 2018 census questionnaire, for example, required the input of one's ethnic group to the chagrin of, especially multi-ethnic homes. Government bureaucratization policies, therefore, need to be overhauled as the current policies solidify ethnic identities to the detriment of national cohesion.

Given that the adopted naming system is a new phenomenon, its effect on Luo identity and efficacy in navigating Kenya's ethnicized space is yet to be established. If the projected outcomes are realized and this adaptation becomes successful in minimizing their disabilities and disadvantages; Kenyan communities may need to consider conversations on reimagining identities as a method of managing negative ethnicity.

Notes

1. The colonial industrial economy preferred non contracted casual laborers who could be acquired and detached on demand. To ensure they received the best from their workers, industries would frequently ask employees to refer workers they knew would perform. Room for nepotism was created thus laborers frequently changed names to acquire wage labor. A more detailed analysis of the labor practices in the colonial period can be found in works of Stichter (1985) and Cooper (1987).
2. Covert to surrounding ethnic groups
3. Eighteen of the sampled middle class had children who could barely speak Luo language. They were also having less visits to their rural homes, and their children some of whom were as old as fifteen had had no or only a few visits to their rural homes. Seven parents who were second-generation urbanites and nine who were third generation, were unable to trace particularities of their roots (clan names, extended family) and only knew of the names of their rural homes. This was in contrast to the four low-income households where individuals tended to know their extended kin not only in the urban areas, but in rural areas most of whom they had never had contact with. Most of the middle-class parents and all the children considered their urban residences rather than their rural homes as their permanent abodes.
4. European colonial administrators in Kenya oscillated between being private citizens in business ventures and public administrators. This created a situation where those in government ended up consolidating all instruments of administration to ensure their private interests in the colony were foremost considered.
5. The first case of ethnic clashes began in 29 October 1991 at Meteitei Farm in Tinderet, Nandi district. Luo farm workers houses were torched by a group of Kalenjin warriors. Leaflets were distributed arguing the Luo to leave the area, and the Kericho Kisumu border became a war zone.

6. The Luo-other Kenyan ethnic groups division has been mainly along the question of circumcision. Traditionally, ethnic Luo do not perform circumcision as a rite of passage to adulthood and in times of conflict, other ethnic groups label them as children.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Belindah Okello is a PhD candidate at Leiden University's Africa Study Center in Leiden, Netherlands. She holds a Bachelor degree in History and Religion from Egerton University; and a Master degree in African History from the same institution. Her Master degree thesis was centered on the development of Western formal education for Africans in the Kenya colony, and it was during this study that the link between the nature of the colonial economy and the need for African functionaries to enable its operations came to light. Hence her interests in migrant populations who serviced the colonial economy. Currently, she is involved in a project analyzing labor migrations and the challenges of integration of migrant Luo population in Mombasa Kenya.

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